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< SHUBMAN GILL, 24

Batsman

T20s: 14, RUNS: 335, SR: 147.57

The poster boy of cricket for Gen-Z in India, Gill may not have made the squad of 15 in this T20 World Cup, but on the evidence of those pulls, drives and punches off the back foot, there's no denying his lethal ball-striking abilities. With Rohit Sharma's leaving the T20I stage, Gill is a prime contender to fill that void. They are big shoes to fill, but Shubman has shown that he can negotiate the new ball and deliver a sumptuous start to the innings. His opening exploits with Gujarat Titans in the IPL in the team's inaugural season last year and in the 2023 Border-Gavaskar series are proof of his ability to both knock sixes and be 'the wall'. In an age where cricketers are valued as much for their game as for their marketable personality, Gill revels in the attention—being seen with celebs, dubbing the Hindi version of *Spider-Man: Across the Spider-Verse* and serving a dishy, sartorial masterclass through Instagram.

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DHRUV JUREL, 23 ^

Wicketkeeper-batsman

IPL MATCHES: 27, RUNS: 347
SR: 151.53; CATCHES: 12

It was on his idol M.S. Dhoni's home ground, Ranchi, that Jurel announced himself to the world. In the past two Tests against England, Jurel put in two steely knocks—90 and 39 not out—leading Sunil Gavaskar to call him the next M.S. Dhoni. "I try to imitate him, but it is very difficult," Jurel told INDIA TODAY at the 2024 India Today Conclave. Vice captain of the 2020 Under 19 World Cup team which finished runners-up, this son of a Kargil War veteran continues to make a fine impression in the IPL with Rajasthan Royals, both with the gloves and the bat.

HARSHIT RANA, 22 >

Fast Bowler

IPL MATCHES: 20
WICKETS: 25, ECONOMY: 9.05

From a net bowler for Gujarat Titans, Harshit's fortunes changed dramatically when he donned the Kolkata Knight Riders jersey in this year's IPL. His defining moment came defending 13 runs in KKR's opening match, a performance he built upon to help secure the team's third IPL title. With 19 wickets, Harshit finished among the top five wicket-takers, boasting a better strike rate than even Jasprit Bumrah. Despite missing the T20 World Cup squad, Harshit soon earned his India call-up for the Zimbabwe tour.



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B. SAI SUDHARSHAN, 22 v

Batsman

IPL MATCHES: 25
RUNS: 1,034, SR: 139.17

This Chennai-born southpaw has been marked for stardom by all who've witnessed his batting prowess. Sai's rise surpassed even Hardik Pandya's prediction, last year, of an India debut within two years. At 22, Sai donned the India colours in an ODI series against South Africa in December, notching two half centuries in three matches. Before his international debut, Sai's resume already boasted two IPL finals, prolific run-scoring for Tamil Nadu, India A appearances and an Emerging Asia Cup title with a century against Pakistan.



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